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Summary of "In Defense of Prejudice" by Jonathan Rauch

In the essay "In Defense of Prejudice", Jonathan Rauch argues that a society in which every individual attempts to legislate every last vestige of prejudice out of existence is actually pursuing a dangerous and ultimately futile form of purism. Rauch advances a defense of "intellectual pluralism," an open system in which offensive ideas are not squelched by institutional censors but are instead confronted in the public square. He sets up his argument as a juxtaposition of worldviews: the "purist movement" that attempts to cleanse the world of prejudice through regulation, and his own pluralist view. From the start, Rauch maintains that pluralism begins with the uncomfortable fact that human beings are naturally imperfect and diverse, and that error and prejudice are part of the price of free societies. He contends that in a truly pluralistic society, no single authority gets to determine which thoughts are "correct". Rauch emphasizes the necessity of this reality by stating, "The very last thing society should do is seek to utterly eradicate racism and other forms of prejudice." (37).

Rauch utilizes this framework to make a broader point: stopping offensive speech by banning it does not work as a matter of practice. He asserts that the disconnect between who we are and who we permit ourselves to be creates a world of pent-up bitterness. Even if there were empirical proof that suppressing speech protected individuals, Rauch would still argue that it is worth the risk to allow it. He posits that society benefits when even the most odious views are dragged into the light of day rather than pushed into the shadows. In this "sunlight" theory of speech, Rauch argues that confronting bad ideas is the best way of dealing with

them. He explains that "Intellectual pluralism... permits the expression of various forms of bigotry... not because it favors them, but because it recognizes that the only way to manage them is to channel them into public criticism." (38). To illustrate his point, he notes that a generation ago, even the Nazis were allowed to march in Skokie, Illinois, because the A.C.L.U. and others recognized their right to do so while simultaneously calling them "creeps". He contrasts this with modern campuses, which he describes as places where students run to administrators with complaints about "unpleasantries".

Furthermore, Rauch compares the marketplace of ideas to a "social" scientific method, which rests on a foundation of the "freedom to error". Just as scientific knowledge grows by permitting theorists to be wrong in order to ultimately find the truth, social progress necessitates a similar intellectual friction. Rauch maintains that truth is not a static goal reached once and for all, but rather a process of continual checking and correcting. By permitting prejudiced ideas to be expressed, society is compelled to recheck and improve its arguments for equality and justice. He argues that this process of "intellectual abrasion" is the only means of truly changing minds at scale. He warns that in the absence of real debate, our most cherished beliefs become "dead dogmas"- assertions held by rote rather than through conviction.

Rauch also delves into the psychological and social impacts of the purist crusade, describing it as an effort to fight bias that results in a "kind of terror". He points out a disturbing contradiction: in the name of protecting minorities, a culture is created where people are afraid to open their mouths for fear of being labeled a bigot. The result, he

contends, is the denial of intellectual development, as honest conversation about difficult topics is stifled in favor of comfort. He observes that when authorities chase "words that wound," they are often distracted from real violence and oppression. He argues that equating words with physical violence is a mischievous business that leads to a society of "mandated re-education" and a loss of true freedom.

In his final assessment, Rauch addresses the inherent danger of granting any institution the power to determine what qualifies as "prejudice". He argues that the very notion that "offensive" speech should be prohibited creates a demand for an "inquisitor". Since the definition of what is offensive is inherently subjective, entrusting those in power with this authority guarantees they will eventually use it against political opponents and reformers. Rauch concludes by asserting that the alternative to a world with some prejudice is a world with the Inquisition. His final point emphasizes that "If we want to protect a free society, we have to be sure no idea is legally 'off-limits' to consider... We must defend the system of free inquiry even when it shelters the people we hate the most." (46). For Rauch, we must defend the system of free expression precisely because it is the only tool marginalized groups have to eventually prevail against ignorant mass opinion.